

Syllables

BREAKING UP WORDS INTO SYLLABLES CAN HELP WITH PRONUNCIATION AND SPELLING.

Every English word consists of one or more syllables. Separating words into syllables helps split complex words into simple, easy-to-remember parts.

Sounding out syllables

One way to determine the correct pronunciation of a word is to break it up into syllables and say each part aloud. For example, the word *melody* can be broken up into three syllables: *me*, *lo*, and *dy*. Single syllable words, such as *cook* and *shop*, are never divided. There are certain rules about how to break up a word.

▷ Long vowel sounds and consonants

If the first part of the word makes a long vowel sound and a consonant comes between two vowels, the word is usually divided before the consonant.

Sa makes a long vowel sound.

sa-ving

The consonant *v* is between two vowels, *a* and *i*.

▷ Single-letter syllables and special sounds

Never separate two or more letters that together make a single sound. A long vowel sounded alone forms a syllable by itself.

Ph sounds like an *f*.

O makes a long vowel sound.

phys-i-o-ther-a-py

Th makes a unique sound.

▷ Short vowel sounds and consonants

If the first part of the word makes a short vowel sound and a consonant comes between two vowels, the word is usually divided after the consonant.

Mod makes a short vowel sound.

mod-est

The consonant *d* is between two vowels, *o* and *e*.

▷ Prefixes and suffixes

A prefix is divided from the root word. If the word ends in the suffix *-le* and this is preceded by a consonant, the word is divided before the consonant.

The prefix *re-* is separated from *handle*.

re-han-dle

The suffix *-le* is preceded by the consonant *d*.

▷ Identical consonants and different vowel sounds

Two identical consonants next to each other are separated. The word is also divided where two different vowel sounds meet. Most suffixes are separated from the root word.

Identical consonants are separated.

Here, *di* and *ate* make different vowel sounds.

im-me-di-ate-ly

The suffix *-ly* is separated from *immediate*.

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REAL WORLD

Haiku poetry

Haiku is a traditional Japanese form of poetry that usually consists of 17 syllables. Although Japanese haiku is printed in a vertical line (pictured), in English it is often written over three lines, with five syllables in the first and third lines, and seven syllables in the middle line.



GLOSSARY

Consonant A letter of the alphabet that is not a vowel.

Prefix A group of letters attached to the start of a word that can change the original word's meaning.

Suffix A group of letters attached to the end of a word that can change the original word's meaning.

Vowel One of the five letters *a*, *e*, *i*, *o*, and *u*.